SWADESHI WHATSAPP

After BJP Union ministers dumped Microsoft for Zoho's indigenous office suite, the RSS, too, has joined the swadeshi surge, moving its internal communications to messaging app **Arattai** (Tamil for chit-chat). Also developed by Sridhar Vembu's Zoho, Arattai has seen eight million downloads since the switch. The move aligns with Prime Minister Modi's recurring call for "digital sovereignty". But can the "banter app" unseat Meta's **WhatsApp,** which has over 500 million Indian users? Experts say nationalism may bring downloads, but not loyalty. Well, the Sangh is certainly trying with its 'make in India, message in India' move.



THE VIDEO STAR

Ex-Union minister **Parshottam Rupala** had found himself out of the Union cabinet after his controversial remarks against the Kshatriya community during the 2024 general election campaign. Not one to fade away easily, the Patidar leader from Saurashtra has since turned into an active YouTuber and promoter of Gujarati literature and culture. The Rajkot MP's channel, 'Moje Dariya', featuring videos of his interviews with literary stars and folk storytellers, has become a huge hit, attracting thousands of 'likes' from fans.

Cultivating Next-Gen ATCs



Airports Authority of India (AAI) is taking an unconventional approach at this year's India International Trade Fair in Delhi. Instead of glossy displays and 3D airport models, it's focusing on inspiring the next generation of **air traffic controllers**. With India's aviation sector booming, the need for skilled ATCs is greater than ever. Young visitors will get to hear live recordings of pilot–controller exchanges, participate in aviation quizzes, and even attempt mock 'ATC courses'. Certificates and exciting prizes await the top performers.

Kaushik Deka with Pradip R. Sagar, Jumana Shah and Avishek G. Dastidar

ECO WATCH

By **Jumana Shah**

WILDLIFE CONSERVATION
A DESI RED-LIST

India has launched its first comprehensive effort to assess the extinction risk of about 11,000 species of plants and animals, in a move that could redefine national biodiversity planning.

Announced by Union MoS for environment Kirti Vardhan Singh at the IUCN World Conservation Congress in Abu Dhabi recently, the National Red List Assessment (NRLA) will evaluate roughly 7,000 flora and 4,000 fauna species to determine their vulnerability. The project, led by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC), will run till 2030 with technical support from the Wildlife Institute of India and the Botanical Survey of India.

Until now, India—home to nearly eight per cent of global biodiversity—has relied largely on global IUCN assessments or fragmented state-level studies. "This will create the first national baseline of extinction risk, enabling evidence-based conservation policy and resource allocation," Singh said, adding the programme will train 300 red-list assessors and produce India's first National Red Data Books.

Experts say the step is overdue. India is one of 17 megadiverse countries, yet about 30 per cent of its plant and animal species are endemic and often poorly studied. Conservation scientists note that national red-list data will strengthen decisions on environmental clearances, protected-area planning and species recovery priorities.

It will also help India meet targets under the Kunming–Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework, which calls for nations to halt biodiversity loss by the end of the decade.

